

Travel and Expense Policy

[wiki/finance/expense-policy](#) · Updated 2026-05-22

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Purpose

This policy explains what business expenses Northwind reimburses and how to submit them. It applies to all employees and contractors who incur costs on behalf of the company. It is maintained by the Finance team.

The policy balances two goals: making it easy for employees to do their jobs without being out of pocket, and keeping spending reasonable and auditable.

General principles

- Spend company money as if it were your own.
- Keep a receipt for everything and submit promptly.
- When unsure, ask before you spend.
- Choose the reasonable option, not the cheapest or the most expensive.

Travel

- Flights should be booked in economy class. Premium cabins require director approval.
- Book travel as far in advance as practical to control cost.

- Ground transport should use standard options; use ride-share or transit over premium services

where reasonable.

- Hotels should be booked at a standard business rate.

Booking travel

Use the approved booking tool where possible so travel is tracked and negotiated rates apply. If you must book outside it, keep the receipts and note why. Combine trips where it makes sense to reduce cost and time away.

Meals during travel

Meals during business travel are reimbursable up to 60 USD per day. This covers all meals combined, not per meal. Alcohol is not reimbursable except at an approved client event.

Client entertainment

Client dinners require manager approval above 150 USD per head. Always record the names and companies of attendees and the business purpose. Reasonable, occasional client entertainment is expected; lavish or frequent entertainment is not.

Documentation for entertainment

For any client entertainment, record who attended, which companies they represented, and the business reason. This is required both for reimbursement and for compliance.

Submitting expenses

- Submit receipts within 30 days through the expense portal.
- Itemise each expense and attach a legible receipt.
- Select the correct cost centre and project code.
- Add a short business justification for anything unusual.

Approval flow

Expenses route to your manager for approval and then to Finance for payment. Approved expenses are typically reimbursed in the next payroll cycle. Incomplete submissions are returned, which delays payment.

Receipts

A valid receipt shows the vendor, date, amount, and what was purchased. A card statement line is not a receipt. If you lose a receipt, note it and provide what detail you can; repeated missing receipts will be questioned.

What is not reimbursable

- Personal expenses are never reimbursable.
- Fines, penalties, and traffic tickets.
- Personal entertainment and non-business subscriptions.
- Upgrades and add-ons that are not pre-approved.

Worked example

An employee travels for two days to meet a client. They book an economy flight through the approved tool, stay at a standard business-rate hotel, and spend within the 60 USD daily meal limit. They host a client dinner at 120 USD per head, which is under the approval threshold, and record the attendees and purpose. They submit itemised receipts within a week and are reimbursed in the next cycle.

Frequently asked questions

What is the daily meal limit while travelling? 60 USD per day, covering all meals combined.

Do I need approval for a client dinner? Yes, if it is above 150 USD per head.

How long do I have to submit? 30 days through the expense portal.

Common mistakes

- Submitting a card statement line instead of an itemised receipt.
- Missing the 30-day window and delaying your own reimbursement.
- Booking premium travel without director approval.
- Mixing personal purchases into a business expense claim.

Questions

If you are unsure whether something is reimbursable, ask Finance before you spend. It is much easier to confirm in advance than to resolve a rejected

claim afterwards.

Related documents

See the Remote Work Policy for equipment stipends and the Data Retention Policy for how financial records are retained.

Corporate cards

Where a corporate card is issued, it is for business expenses only. The card does not change what is reimbursable; it changes how the expense is paid. Reconcile card charges in the expense portal just as you would a personal out-of-pocket expense.

- Use the corporate card only for approved business expenses.
- Reconcile every charge with an itemised receipt in the portal.
- Report a lost or stolen card to Finance and the issuer immediately.
- Never use the corporate card for personal purchases, even intending to repay.

Approvals and limits

Approval requirements scale with amount and category. Most routine expenses need only your manager's approval; larger or unusual spending needs additional sign-off.

- Routine travel and meals within the limits need manager approval only.

- Client entertainment above the per-head threshold needs manager approval in advance.
- Premium travel needs director approval.
- Anything unusual should be cleared with Finance before you commit the spend.

When an expense is likely to be questioned, attach a short justification up front. A clear note at submission time is far faster than a back-and-forth after the fact.